

Evolution Of MP3 Players

The earliest precursors to portable digital audio players were portable CD players and mini disc players. The Eiger Labs MPMAN F10, a 32 MB portable digital player, was one of the earliest non-mechanical digital audio players in the American market and was released in 1998.

The first big selling Digital Audio Player (DAP) was the Rio PMP300 from Diamond Multimedia, introduced in September 1998. The huge success of the Rio player brought about a large amount of interest and investment in the digital music sector. Other early DAPs included Sensory Science's Rave MP2100, the I-Jam IJ-100, and the Creative Labs Nomad. These portables were small and light, and

could hold around 7 to 20 songs at normal 128 Kbps compression, and had compact flash memories for storage.

By 2000 when USB ports had gained popularity and were increasingly used to transfer data, digital audio players came integrated with them. At around this time a company called Remote Solutions made a significant improvement in the storage problems faced by DAPs by using a laptop hard drive for storing songs rather than the low-capacity flash memory. The Personal Jukebox (PJB-100) had 4.8 GB of storage space, and held about 1,200 songs. This was the beginning of what would be called the jukebox segment of digital audio players. This segment eventually went onto become

the dominant one in MP3 players.

Apple computers then released their iconic iPod in 2001, along with the iTunes music download service. They also released versions that could hold over 30 GB of data including images and music files. This opened the floodgates of the industry and the market was soon inundated with players offering various storage capacities and also recording and playback capabilities.

In a reversal of sorts, with advances in flash memory technologies, companies today are heading back to flash storage from solid state storage devices. The recently released iPod Nano has up to 4 GB of flash-based storage capacity.

Battery Life

Some of the players had strange quirks. For instance, the MSI MegaStick would hang when battery power was running out. We should mention that the same batteries powered other players without problems.

The YES YMP-910 was the best in terms of battery life, and scored the highest with 27.5 hours of non-stop play. It uses an internal Li-Ion battery. The Samsung YP-C1 followed it with 27 hours of continuous play on an AA external alkaline battery. This also brings into perspective the question of what is better—internal Li-Ion or external AA or AAA batteries.

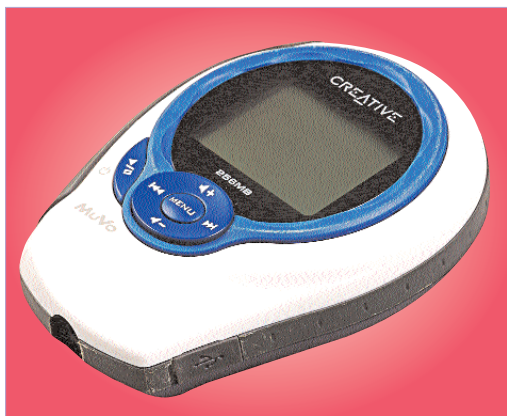
While Li-ion offers the possibility of charging from a PC via USB, AA or AAA batteries give you the freedom of keeping a backup when in need. For us, an external battery is much more utilitarian than an internal one. Of course, this is only a general perspective that we are offering, and in no way affects the scores in this test.

Other players that put in a commendable performance included the Bravish, Smedia Butterfly and the MSI MegaStick.

Conclusion

The flash-based portable audio category saw some stiff competition. Almost all the players except the Creative MuVo Mix and the iPod Shuffle had displays. Granted that not having a display does increase battery life, but managing or listening to songs on a player that lacks a display can be quite cumbersome.

Another factor that resulted in the tough competition was the features that are available on all the players. Features, such as video, were exclusive to only one player while features like text and image viewing are available on quite a few.



Rugged build quality identifies the Creative MuVo C100

This time around we have a tie for the Digit 'Best Buy Gold' award—the Samsung YP-T8 and the YES YMP-910. These players performed very well in the audio quality department without compromising on features.

The Digit 'Best Buy Silver' award goes to the iRiver T30. This is one spunky little gadget that packs a wallop when it comes to audio quality. With a price of Rs 4,999, this player is a must-buy.

HARD DRIVE-BASED PLAYERS

Flash-based players can offer all the comforts of having a portable digital audio player that is rugged and can withstand the roughest of shocks, but it can never offer the capacity of a hard drive-based player. Hard drive (HDD) players such as the iPod can hold your entire music collection, and then some.

We received eight HDD-based players for our comparison this time, including the iPods. All of these were feature packed and proved to be quite a handful in our comparison tests. For all the juicy details, read on...

Features

So what is new in the HDD based portable players scene? Well, a lot, we must say. Let's find out.

Display

Amongst the HDD-based portable players, the Samsung YH-J70 had the most features. It is the elder sibling of the YP-T8 that we checked out in the flash-based players comparison. Only, in this player, the screen is smaller. The Samsung YH-J70 again has a 262K TFT-LCD screen similar to the YP-T8 flash model.

Next up was the iRiver. The player also featured an OLED screen with 262K colour depth. The other players featured the regular LCD screens and some changing lights (which actually look bad) such as on the Creative ZEN NEEON.

The Creative MuVo 2 player's display was too small for its size. The display is a two-line LCD screen. It serves the purpose, but viewing tracks on the player becomes cumbersome since you can only check two track names at a time when scrolling.